

Choose a film or TV series which depicts translators or interpreters or contains scenes in which interpreting or translation is important. Discuss the way the film portrays the fictional translators or interpreters, the translation/interpreting process and the linguistic and cultural differences. You can also select two films and compare how the translators/interpreters are represented.

Wes Anderson's animation *Isle of Dogs* (2018) tells the story of English-speaking dogs persecuted and deported to Trash Island by a dog-hating regime in the fictional *Megasaki City* in Japan. The original version of this film is created for an English-speaking audience, yet Anderson avoids adding English subtitles over the Japanese dialogue. After the prologue, a brief title screen writes: 'The humans in this story speak only in their native tongue (occasionally translated via bilingual interpreter, foreign-exchange-student, or electronic device). All barks have been rendered into English,' (Anderson 2018). He uses several interpretation methods instead, to allow a foreignized storytelling of *Isle of Dogs* which 'preserves the Japanese language and atmosphere' (Statha 2024). This essay will focus specifically on the electronic devices and the interpreter but also on areas where there is intentionally no translation. Venuti proposes a foreignization of translation which 'focuses on the signified' (the source text), and 'eschews fluency' by allowing a 'heterogeneous mix of discourses' (Venuti 2003: 28). In this film, the different interpretation methods can be viewed as discourses impacting the storytelling and its impact on the viewer in various ways, whilst creating 'foreignized' (Venuti 2003) and eschewed translations of Japanese dialogue. Ultimately, this disrupts the passive consumption of the film, reminding the viewer of the 'pre-anthropological' emotional connection necessary even in a futuristic context.

Technological Alienation

The film employs several electronic devices to interpret for the audience and between characters. A rolling LED display is used to translate Mayor Kobayashi who states ‘この国の法律に従って反対意見も容認する’ (Anderson 2018) and on the LED board it states: ‘Our legal system provides for: DISSENTING OPINION!’ (Anderson 2018). This display had been hidden from the viewer until this point, as an extra-diegetic narrator had summarised the important content of Kobayashi’s speech. The LED screen is the first tool in the film to directly translate language to the viewer, following Diaz-Cintas’ rule of thumb: translation in film must occur in such a way to make viewers aware of the language difference (Jorge Díaz Cintas 2011). Anderson establishes a *Verfremdungseffekt* (Brecht and Hewitt 1961), which encourages the viewer to watch critically, by employing a shallow depth of field which focuses on the screen and blurs the speakers in the background, which work in conjunction with the language barrier. The non-Japanese speaking viewer is made aware of their position as a viewer and of their role within this interlingual communication, and the blurring of the characters creates an emotional distance between them and the viewer.

The film uses a fictional take on a shorthand text-speech device, the keys in Japanese alphabetised. The person vigorously transcribing the Japanese dialogue occupies the right side of the screen, the shot gradually cuts closer to a close-up shot, which draws our attention to sweat dripping down his forehead. The speech is interpreted by the *Simultranslator*, which congratulates Kitana for creating ‘the most promising artificial life form in the history of corporate technology’ (the military robot dogs) (Anderson 2018). There’s a unique irony here which highlights the cost of

human labour (the sweat) whilst the idle Kitana sits comfortably, stroking her cat, having created 'artificial life forms' that can carry out her legacy. Meanwhile the interpreter is not congratulated for his work, even though translation is 'a form of labour' (Cronin 2017: 71).

Atari and his dog Spots use earpieces to communicate seamlessly between English and Japanese. When the two first meet, sans earpieces, they already bridge an emotional connection, with Atari putting out his hand for Spots to lick. After receiving the earpieces, they both start crying, which shows the emotionally groundbreaking potential from interspecies communication. The encounter among species changes once they gain the ability to communicate, transforming them from an object to a subject, (Hathaway 2024) and in this case, Spots becomes the focus of the scene. The shot type changes from a medium shot to a close-up shot of Spots. He repeatedly states 'I can hear you, I can hear you', with Atari's dialogue quietened in the background (Anderson 2018). This allows Anderson to portray Spots as a 'blank screen for anthropocentric projection and subjection', (Cronin 2017: 92) as he is suddenly able to communicate with Atari and displays emotions in a very human way: through tears.

If the viewer is not careful, the anthropomorphic portrayal of human emotions on Spots can undermine the underlying foundations already established by the licking of the hand. Additionally, Atari attempts to use it like a telephone by saying: 'もしもし' (*moshimoshi*), a phrase used in Japanese when picking up a phone, even though it's a live-translation device. This undermines and somewhat criticises the cyberutopian idea that technology could seamlessly create interspecies communication, as Atari

treats it as a conversation on the phone, rather than as a ‘magic’ tool which could bridge barriers instantly.

The imperfect interpreter

Across the film there are several TV conferences which are interpreted by Nelson.

The booth in which she sits, marked off by a pane of glass is a ‘typical social and geographic non-place’ (Kaindl 2014: 3). Her unchanging outfit also limits her to this role, putting her somewhat in line with Kaindl’s theory, that interpreters within a fictional context are attributed ambivalent characteristics, unable to take a side.

(Kaindl 2014: 9) Yet this is subverted several times by her stark display of emotions, blurring the lines between her role as an emotional ambassador to the audience and as an interpreter.

In the film’s diegetic landscape, the Kobayashi regime is dictatorial and adamantly anti-dog, yet the allegiances of Nelson appear to lie elsewhere. In the initial Science Party Speech, Nelson makes a key shift: as Watanabe (leader of the Science Party) speaks, she matches his tone in her interpretation, re-expressing his emotions in the first person: ‘I’m this close, dammit’. This is accompanied by extra diegetic *taiko* music, and images of dogs which float above the leader, forming a visually engaging, passionate speech. As the Science Party leader states his last line ‘犬は人間の友で

もないのか’ with a tear dripping down his face, the edit returns to an eye-level shot of

Nelson with a dimmed expression stating quietly: ‘whatever happened to man’s best friend,’ (Anderson 2018) carrying through the sadness expressed by the science leader. On the other hand, when mayor Kobayashi speaks, Nelson is no longer in the frame, and she transposes his speech into the third person, distancing herself from the opinions of Kobayashi and translating her allegiance. This is an example of

where codes of interpreting oscillate (Kaindl 2014) and shows translation as an open-ended diplomatic negotiation (Cronin 2017). In the name of the narrative's agenda, Nelson steps outside the role of an 'invisible' translator (Venuti 2003) and instead becomes an emotional storyteller. However, this can also be read through an orientalist lens: Western coded characters are required to rationalise the native Japanese voice (Prawira, Ramadhan, and Alivin 2025).

Although she remains neutral in her commentary across most of the film, she slips up further, again nudging the narrative towards being 'pro-dog'. The haiku at the end of the film is also left untranslated by the interpreter as she is driven to tears by it, showing the emotional weight of translation. The eye contact with the audience as she narrates the speeches and events of the film, is key in acknowledging the fourth wall, establishing a 'closeness effect' by connecting the viewer to an animation which they know is 'not real' and thus 'can only involve you more' (Wijers 2018), and further pushes them into the pro-dog narrative.

The film also features two other human interpreters: a young boy (Jr. Interpreter Ernie) in the same glass box that Nelson stands in. He sometimes stutters, appearing vulnerable and nervous. The use of Ernie is unexpected, especially as Nelson is the interpreter for all other characters in the film. On the one hand, the use of Ernie reflects Atari's age and gender, but on the other hand his nervous demeanour and vulnerability from his youth reflect the political tension in the film: Atari, the nephew of mayor Kobayashi, is missing and there is increasing scepticism towards Kobayashi's anti-dog regime. Kaindl argues that interpreters in fiction are represented as 'symptoms of a problem that affects the entire society'. (Kaindl 2014) Nelson also watches over Ernie, which somewhat acts as a symptom of the authoritarian nature of the regime via surveillance.

Pre-anthropological connection via non-translation

There is an additional method: the non-translation, which ‘eschews verbal fluency’ further (Venuti 2003: 28). At several points in the film there is Japanese dialogue which Anderson does not translate at all, putting the English-speaking audience at a theoretical loss. The narrative relies instead on alternative cues: In MacDougall’s *Transcultural Cinema*, it is said that ‘images provide ways of perceiving humanity that are not only transcultural but pre-anthropological’ (MacDougall 1998: 258): facial expressions, social codes, vocal intonations etc. provide alternative pathways to understanding an otherwise unintelligible character, thus speaking and understanding a language is just one out of many ways that someone can be understood.

For example, Atari passionately delivers an unsubtitled speech to the dogs on trash island, even stating: 人間と犬の戦争になるよ (‘There’s going to be a war between dogs and humans.’) Though it’s untranslated to a non-Japanese speaking viewer, his tone of voice is emotional, and his facial expressions are angry. Yet the dogs sit and stare, relatively unaffected by the emotions of Atari. Duke sits in the foreground of the shot and states quite bluntly: ‘I wish somebody spoke his language’ (Anderson 2018). This reminds the viewer of the limits of relying on pre-anthropological cues: there are inevitable misunderstandings, or ‘irreducible realities of language and culture.’ (Cronin 2009) It also oddly flips the roles of the human notion of remaining ‘deaf to the needs and plight of other species,’ where humans make no effort to find a way to communicate with other species (Cronin 2017). It also reassesses the *tradosphere*: ‘the sum of all translation systems on the planet,’ (Cronin 2017: 71) by decentring the human within the ‘Great Story’. Atari is

unintelligible to both the dogs and to the human non-Japanese speaking viewer. His emotions can easily be seen as passionate and barbaric, as the audience misses key aspects of his speech, even though he states: いい犬だ! (Anderson 2018), which translates to: 'What good dogs you are!' It highlights the importance that the role of mutual intelligibility has taken up in modern society, as pre-anthropological codes are overlooked in favour of spoken language.

Conclusion

Anderson's *Isle of Dogs* evaluates the complex nuances of futuristic translation technology in both an interhuman and interspecies context. Anderson enforces otherness on every subject, even onto the viewer, to show that no one is immune to the side effects of this potential technology. Translation technology is displayed as limited in its ability to build emotional connections, the imperfect non-objective interpreter acts as an emotional guide for the non-Japanophone viewer, and scenes without any translation reveal the reliance modern society places on interlingual communication. This visibility of translation somewhat disputes accusations of orientalism put on the film as it does not degrade 'otherness' but rather gently reminds us of inevitable intercultural barriers by eschewing fluency (Venuti 2003) and by disrupting the 'universal currency of the gaze' (Cronin 2009, p. 120). Amidst violent robot dogs and *Babel fish* style translation technologies, interspecies and intercultural understanding is achieved not solely by cyberutopian, objective interpreting but rather via 'pre-anthropological' emotional connection.

1998 words

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